

Session 25: A Heroine From the Non-Chosen Family

Key Takeaways

- Genesis 22:20-24 is a hinge between major sections of the Avraham story, both concluding the previous section and pointing forward to the next.
- Rivqah (Rebekah) introduces the pattern of heroines of the faith from non-chosen families, which runs through the whole Hebrew Bible.
- Biblical characters are mirrors in which we examine ourselves as well as our communities and cultures.

Movement III: Blessing for the Next Generation

This final stretch of the Avraham story consists of four literary units of uneven length, but they systematically develop the core themes of the story as we transition to the next generation.

Genesis 22:20-24

The Genealogy and Birth of Avraham's Brother Leading to Rivqah

- List of 12 sons + Rivqah

Genesis 23:1-20

The Death of Sarah and Burial in Makpelah

Genesis 24:1-67

Avraham's Servant Sent to Avraham's Brother So Yitskhaq Can Marry Rivqah

Genesis 25:1-6

List of Avraham's Non-Chosen Sons Through Qeturah + Yitskhaq and Rivqah Are Chosen

Genesis 25:7-11

The Death of Avraham and Burial in Makpelah

Genesis 25:12-18

The Genealogy of the Unchosen Yishmael

- List of 12 sons

Genesis 22:20-25:18 (Detailed). Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

What's fascinating is that this conclusion to the Avraham story is recalled at the conclusion of the Yaaqov (Jacob) story as well. The final segments of the Yaaqov narrative mirror both the content and the sequence in Genesis 22:20-25:18.

Genesis 35:16-20

The Death and Burial of Rachel

Genesis 35:21-26

List of Yaaqov's Wives and Children

Genesis 35:27-29

The Death and Burial of Yitskhaq in Machpelah

Genesis 36:1-8

List of Esau's Wives and Children

Genesis 36:9-43

The Genealogy of the Unchosen Esau

Genesis 35:16-36:43. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

The transition sections between the Avraham and Yaaqov narratives and between the Yaaqov and Joseph narratives are aligned. This alignment is important because it allows us to see the compositional analogies between the major parts of Genesis.



Diagram showing where genealogies in Genesis branch between chosen and non-chosen lines.

Genealogies in Genesis. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

This pattern actually highlights an important compositional design that occurs throughout the entire Genesis scroll. The main narrative traces the lineage of the promised seed to a set of siblings. Then, after the story of their separation, the non-chosen line is ushered off the stage with a genealogy that extends far past the narrative time perspective. After this, the narrative backtracks and focuses on the chosen line, picking up their story.

Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 22:20-24

²⁰ And it came about after these things,
then it was reported to **Avraham**, saying,

"Look, **Milkah**, **she also** **has given birth** to sons for **Nakhor your brother** :

²¹ Uts his firstborn,

and Buz his brother,

and Qemuel the father of Aram

²² and Kesed and Khazo and Pildash and Yidlaph and **Betuel** ."

²³ Now, **Betuel**, **he caused the birth** **Rivqah** .

These eight **Milkah** birthed for **Nakhor the brother of Avraham** .

²⁴ And as for his concubine, her name was Reumah,

and **she also** **gave birth** to Tevakh and Gakhm and Takhash and Maakah.

Genesis 22:20-24. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

What Is This Story Doing Here?

This short narrative and genealogy are fascinating for many reasons. They form a literary frame around chapters 12-22, as the family of Avraham's brother Nakhor was the focus of the short genealogy at the beginning of Avraham's story in [Genesis 11:27-28](#).

They address an implicit question that was raised by God's oath to Avraham in the previous story.

- a ¹⁷ that I will certainly **bless** you,
b and I will certainly **multiply** **your seed**,
c **like the stars of the skies**,
c' and **like the sand upon the edge of the sea**,
b' and **your seed** will inherit the gate of their enemies,
a' ¹⁸ and all the nations of the land will find **blessing** in your seed,
on the heel of the fact that you listened to my voice."

Genesis 22:1-19. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

We know that Yitskhaq is the chosen son, but if he is going to inherit the promises made to Avraham and has many children ... who will be his wife?

Notice that Nakhor has twelve sons, just like Avraham's son Yishmael ([Gen. 25:12-18](#)) and his grandson Yaakov ([Gen. 36:16-20](#)).

A Heroine From the Non-Chosen Family

This story also begins a key theme that repeats itself many times over throughout the Hebrew Bible: God raises up a female heroine from a non-chosen lineage whose faithfulness carries forward the lineage of promise.

- Rivqah (Rebekah): In Genesis 24, she is depicted as a faithful female counterpart to Avraham.
- Leah: In Genesis 29-30, she is the persistent, unloved wife who gives birth to Judah.
- Tamar: In Genesis 38, she is the courageous woman who risks her social integrity to save the lineage.
- Pharaoh's daughter: In Exodus 2, she rescues Moses out of the waters.
- Tsipporah: In Exodus 4, she rescues Moses from God's judgment.
- Rahab: In Joshua 2, she rescues the Israelite spies.
- Deborah and Jael: In Judges 4-5, these women rescue the Israelites.
- Hannah, Avigail, the wise woman of Tekoa, the wise woman of Abel-Beth, Maakah, Ruth, and more!!

Reflection Question

How would you describe the function of biblical characters for readers of Scripture? Are they models, mirrors, or something else?